Like Alcoholic Liver Disease, NAFLD, too, is most commonly diagnosed when the liver shows more than 5 per cent of fat. In 2021, a meta analysis of 62 data sets from 50 studies on NAFLD published in the *Journal of Clinical and Experimental Hepatology* found 38 per cent of adults in India to have NAFLD, with Chandigarh having the largest share at 53.5 per cent. The prevalence among children was 35 per cent. "The incidence of NAFLD is on the rise in India," says Dr Tom Cherian, liver transplant surgeon at Wockhardt Hospitals, Mumbai Central. "In fact, it is a global pandemic. However, unlike previous pandemics, this one is hitting India hard because we are the world's centre for diabetes and central obesity, particularly fat around the abdomen."

But you don't have to be fat to have NAFLD. It was a question, in fact, Bhalla kept asking himself: if I am not fat, how can my liver be? A 2021 study in the journal *Clinical Liver Disease* found 10-15 per cent of Indian NAFLD patients to be lean, with a normal body mass index (BMI). "Even though it is much more common in overweight and obese people," says Dr S.K. Sarin, noted hepatologist and chairman of the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences in Delhi, "you don't need to be fat or eat fat to have a fatty liver." Consuming excess calories—beyond the WHO-recommended 2,500 for men and 2,000 for women—raises blood glucose, which is converted into fat and stored in the body. The liver also stores glucose, so a high-calorie diet contributes to fat buildup in the organ. Additionally, a diet rich in saturated or trans fats, frequent alcohol consumption, and excess abdominal fat (over 90 cm for men, 80 cm for women) further promote fat accumulation in and around the liver.

People usually discover they have NAFLD by accident. It does not show up in blood tests in the initial stages. In fact, Dr Cherian points out that liver function tests do not always



"Fatty liver is the cause of a number of health issues such as **hypertension, diabetes, thyroid issues, cancers; they can even cause heart attacks**. It is crucial to maintain a healthy liver"

–DR S.K. SARIN
Hepatologist and Chairman, Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences, Delhi

THE NAFLD EPIDEMIC

Non-alcoholic fatty liver disease (NAFLD) has few symptoms in the early stages. It is a disease that gradually creeps up on you without your realising it. A few things to watch out for

WHAT IS NAFLD?

It is the accumulation of fat in the liver in people who do not drink alcohol. Like its counterpart, alcoholic liver disease, NAFLD is diagnosed when the liver has more than 5 per cent fat

SYMPTOMS OF NAFLD

In the early stages, there are very few symptoms; nor does its traces show up initially in blood work. Later, these symptoms may present themselves:

- Fatigue
- Pain in the upper right abdomen area
- Weakness
- Sudden weight loss

DIAGNOSTICS FOR NAFLD

These are the tests used to diagnose NAFLD at different stages:

- **Abdominal ultrasound, MRI or CT scan:** These help visualise the appearance of the liver. It is usually the ultrasound that is first recommended
- **Transient elastography**: This helps measure the amount of fat or stiffness in the organ
- **Liver biopsy:** Performed if there is suspicion of advanced liver disease or some other cause

MASLD: THE NEW NAME FOR NAFLD

MASLD (metabolic dysfunction-associated steatotic liver disease) is the new term for NAFLD. MASLD refers to patients with hepatic steatosis and at least one of five risk factors: high BP, high blood sugar, abdominal obesity, low HDL cholesterol or high triglycerides. The renaming aims to eliminate stigmatising and exclusionary terms such as 'alcoholic' and 'fatty'